his authority. “Our people”—*Khoudi* in the Persian language—were those belonging to elites. Anyone who was not a member of the *Khoudi* had no right to express criticism of any kind. The Supreme National Security Council was made up of Khamenei’s chief consultants and was the channel through which the supreme leader’s decisions were communicated to all state apparatuses. There was also the Assembly of Experts and the Council for the Preservation of Interests. The former appointed the supreme leader, and the latter approved or rejected the decisions of the Majlis (the Iranian parliament). The two councils had a majority of clerics, and their job was to preserve the supreme status of religion in the state.

In another circle were the commanders of the IRGC and the armed forces, who were appointed by the supreme leader and senior clerics from the holy city of Qom. President (from 2005 to 2013) Ahmadinejad was acting prime minister, drawing his authority from the supreme leader. However, he supported and advanced the IRGC, and they in return supported him. The media were also subject to the authority of the supreme leader.

The Iranian population was young. In 2010, about 70 percent of Iranians were under the age of thirty-five. There were at least thirty- six different ethnic groups, each with its own language, culture, and customs. The rule of the mullahs—Islamic clerics—had caused unrest among these groups, although there were no signs of coordination between them. Still, all of them, and especially the largest ones—the Azeris in the northwest, the Arabs in Khuzestan in the south, the Kurds, and the Baloch—demanded some degree of self-determination, ranging from autonomy to full independence. This struggle was expressed by demonstrations, strikes, and sometimes even acts of terrorism. But at that point (and at the time of writing this book, in 2018) these groups did not pose a serious threat to the government.

In the years leading up to 2018, the power structure of the ruling elite was changing. The IRGC were gaining more and more power and influence. The number of senior officers who had been released after a lengthy service in the IRGC was increasing, and now they were taking the places of members of the first generation of the revolution. In 2010 former IRGC members made up about half of government ministers and about a third of the members of the Majlis. At least twenty of Iran’s thirty provinces were controlled by former IRGC members, and Iran’s most important